
Sumo wrestling at the Royal Albert Hall – picture essay

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Athleticism, power and ceremonial splendour were all on display at London's Albert Hall last week as sumo wrestling returned to the storied venue for the first time in 34 years. The ancient Japanese sport has roots tracing back more than 1,500 years, but this was only the second time that a major event had been hosted abroad. It was a remarkable spectacle both inside and outside of the sacred *dohyo* ring.

Big in London

Before the start of the five-day Grand Sumo Tournament, the wrestlers, known as *rikishi*, visited several London landmarks dressed in their silk *kesho-mawashi* robes. They also posed for official portraits with their hair tied in traditional topknots, called *oicho*, and showcased their remarkable appetites. Each sumo – some of whom weigh upwards of 180kg – consumes up to 10,000 calories per day, including almost 2kg of rice.

Preparing the dohyo

The sacred sumo wrestling ring is called a *dohyo*. It is a five-metre wide platform and its construction combines centuries-old tradition with precise engineering. It requires 11 tonnes of soil, plus sand and cement. The surface is pounded with wooden mallets, creating its characteristic texture. Straw bales, known as *tawara*, mark the boundary of the ring. These bales are hammered into shape using old Asahi beer bottles. Above the ring is a canopy, known as the *yakata*, which is modelled after the roof of a Shinto shrine. All the elements are carefully constructed by full-time employees known as *yobidashi*.

Ritual and ceremony

Sumo is a sport packed with rituals, from a special blessing ceremony before the tournament in which referees pour *sake*, chestnuts, salt, rice and dried squid or cuttlefish into a hole at the centre of the *dohyo*, to the iconic leg-stomping of the sumo wrestlers as they try to ward off evil spirits before each bout. Salt is also thrown by the wrestlers to cleanse and purify the arena, creating a glittering effect under the spotlights.

Fighting with spirit

A sumo match begins when the referee shouts *hakkeyoi*, which loosely means "fight with spirit!" The competitors must then grapple, push, slap and propel one another outside the ring, often using one another's sumo belts (*mawashi*) for leverage. The loser is the first wrestler to touch the ground with any part of his body other than his feet, or the first to be thrown outside of the ring's perimeter. Spectators sitting on ringside cushions were forewarned by the event's organisers that they did so entirely at their own risk. The venue even took out additional insurance to cover the possibility of a *rikishi* landing on and injuring someone ringside.

The finale

In the history of sumo wrestling there have only been 75 *yokozuna* – the highest rank of sumo – two of whom are currently active: [Hoshoryu Tomokatsu](#) and [Onosato Daiki](#). Predictably, after each winning their previous four fights, they faced off in the final bout at the Albert Hall, with Hoshoryu, who hails from Mongolia, winning the contest by pushing his larger opponent out of the ring. The tournament then concluded with all 40 sumo wrestlers bidding an emotional farewell to the London crowd.

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